

Dear Living Savior Brothers and Sisters,



I write this letter to you with great joy in my heart and to take the opportunity to update many of you as to the current status of an essential and fulfilling element of my ministry here at Living Savior, that is, my campus ministry to George Mason.

As many of you have likely wondered, and probably correctly assumed, the pandemic has forced George Mason's ministry efforts to look quite different from in years past. Currently, much of the student body has moved back home to live with the family as the bulk of their classes are conducted online. This includes many in the international student community who have traditionally served as the focus of Living Savior's efforts in campus ministry in the past. As a result, it is difficult to find and meet new students who might potentially be interested in involving themselves in traditional ministry efforts like bible studies and home groups. Additionally, many of the students in the area are highly risk-averse to the possibility of exposure to the coronavirus and trouble with the university over engaging in gatherings larger than ten, which is currently a violation of University policy, even if the gathering is off-campus. Trouble for many of these students involves much more than just a slap on the wrist or a possible censure since their legal status in the country often depends on their good standing with George Mason.

To this end, the ministry opportunities at George Mason have been sparse. Gone are the days when I can conveniently put myself on campus and invite students to join and interact with me in a public forum, as former vicars have done. Many of the activities that occurred in prior years, like monthly dinners, have been canceled due to lack of attendance and school policy restrictions. The number of students involved in campus ministers' work has also experienced a precipitous decline going from tens and twenties to ones and twos.

Still, the word of the Lord goes forth, and it shall not come back empty. Despite the often-difficult nature of the work, I am happy to report that there are glimmers of the gospel amid the darkness. To name just two examples, I am currently meeting with two international students whose names and countries of origin will be withheld for security purposes. We have been discussing general topics of religion and faith with one and the distinctions between Lutheranism and Islam, their homeland's dominant faith. With the other, we are currently reading through Matthew's gospel and discussing what the bible teaches us about God. Particularly the unique claims to the divinity of Christ as evident in the gospel.

While these encounters don't involve scores of eager and attentive students, the conversations I have had and the relationships I have built with these two men are worth so much more to me than a crowd. These are men that I hope and intend to maintain a relationship with well after my time here at George Mason and whose friendships have been of great value to me in my time at Living Savior.

Ultimately, to put a theological bent to my letter, the seed is being sown diligently. Much of the seed has fallen amongst the rocky path and has yet to reach the soil at the heart of the nations. But the seed has landed and is growing rich and deep roots through the Holy Spirit's guidance. For these small but exciting successes, I thank God every day.

May the Lord richly bless you in your own lives as you experience the joy of the small gains of life in the face of the darkness of our current situation.

Sincerely,

Vicar Tim